An Axiomatic Meta-Theory of Meta-Theories

A Self-Referential Framework based on an Exponential Correctness Principle

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Abstract

We introduce an axiomatic Meta-Theory of Meta-Theories (MTMT). The central assumption is that the fraction of incorrect meta-theories equals

$$\frac{e-1}{e},$$

leaving exactly

$$\frac{1}{e}$$

of all meta-theories correct.

This assumption induces an exponential hierarchy of confidence across successive meta-levels. The framework is analyzed using mathematical logic, probability theory, statistics, decision theory, theoretical computer science, economics, philosophy, artificial intelligence, and related disciplines. Connections to natural and social sciences are presented as formal analogies or possible research directions rather than empirical claims.

The paper ends with "The End"

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1 Introduction

Scientific theories explain phenomena.

Meta-theories explain theories.

A meta-theory of meta-theories studies the entire collection of possible meta-theories themselves.

This paper assumes one simple axiom:

$$P(\text{incorrect}) = \frac{e-1}{e}.$$

The objective is to investigate its mathematical consequences.

2 Notation

Let

$$\mathcal{M}$$

denote the universe of all meta-theories.

Define

$$C \subseteq \mathcal{M}$$

as the set of correct meta-theories.

Its complement is

$$I = \mathcal{M} \setminus C.$$

Throughout,

$$e = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{1}{n!}.$$

3 Foundational Axioms

Axiom 1 (Universe)**.** *There exists a set*

$$\mathcal{M}$$

whose members are meta-theories.

Axiom 2 (Correctness)**.** *Each element of*

$$\mathcal{M}$$

is either correct or incorrect.

Axiom 3 (Exponential Correctness Principle)**.** *The fraction of incorrect meta-theories equals*

$$\frac{|I|}{|\mathcal{M}|} = \frac{e-1}{e}.$$

Equivalently,

$$\frac{|C|}{|\mathcal{M}|} = \frac{1}{e}.$$

4 Probability Theory

Therefore,

$$P(C) = \frac{1}{e},$$

and

$$P(I) = 1 - \frac{1}{e}.$$

The expectation of correctness is

$$E[X] = \frac{1}{e},$$

where

$$X = \begin{cases} 1, & \text{correct} \\ 0, & \text{incorrect.} \end{cases}$$

Variance becomes

$$\mathrm{Var}(X) = \frac{1}{e}\left(1 - \frac{1}{e}\right).$$

5 Confidence Across Meta-Levels

Suppose

$$T_1, T_2, \ldots, T_n$$

are independently selected meta-levels.
Then

$$P(\text{all correct}) = \left(\frac{1}{e}\right)^n = e^{-n}.$$

Theorem 1. *Confidence decays exponentially with meta-depth.*

Proof. By independence,

$$P = \prod_{i=1}^{n} \frac{1}{e} = e^{-n}.$$

□

6 Self-Reference

Suppose MTMT itself belongs to

$$\mathcal{M}.$$

Then

$$P(\text{MTMT correct}) = \frac{1}{e}.$$

Hence the theory assigns its own correctness the same prior probability assigned to every other member.

No contradiction follows because the framework specifies a prior rather than an absolute truth value.

7 Formal Logic

Let

$$M(x)$$

mean
"x is a meta-theory."
Let

$$C(x)$$

mean
"x is correct."
The axioms become

$$\forall x \left(M(x) \to (C(x) \vee \neg C(x)) \right),$$

and

$$P(C(x) \mid M(x)) = \frac{1}{e}.$$

8 Statistics

Suppose a sample of size

$$n$$

is drawn.
Expected number of correct meta-theories:

$$E[K] = \frac{n}{e}.$$

Variance:

$$n\frac{1}{e}\left(1 - \frac{1}{e}\right).$$

For large samples,

$$K \approx N\left(\frac{n}{e}, n\frac{1}{e}\left(1 - \frac{1}{e}\right)\right).$$

9 Decision Theory

Suppose each accepted incorrect meta-theory incurs loss

$$L_I,$$

while rejecting a correct one incurs

$$L_C.$$

Expected loss becomes

$$\frac{e-1}{e}L_I + \frac{1}{e}L_C.$$

Bayesian decision rules naturally arise from this prior.

10 Economics

Interpret each meta-theory as an intellectual investment.

Expected informational value:

$$V = \frac{1}{e}R - \left(1 - \frac{1}{e}\right)C,$$

where

$$R$$

is informational return and

$$C$$

is evaluation cost.

The framework predicts diminishing expected value for increasingly speculative meta-levels.

11 Finance

Suppose each meta-theory is an asset.

Expected portfolio value:

$$E[P] = \sum_i w_i \frac{1}{e} r_i.$$

Diversification reduces exposure to any single incorrect framework.

12 Physics

No physical law is derived from the MTMT axioms. However, exponential decay appears in many physical systems:

$$N(t) = N_0 e^{-\lambda t}.$$

The MTMT confidence function

$$e^{-n}$$

shares the same mathematical form while representing logical confidence rather than physical decay.

13 Chemistry

Reaction reliability may conceptually resemble chained meta-validation:

$$Y_n = Y_0 e^{-n}.$$

This is an analogy, not an experimentally established chemical law.

14 Biology

Hierarchical biological regulation often contains multiple control layers.

If each regulatory abstraction required independent validation, MTMT predicts exponential reduction in confidence with increasing abstraction depth.

15 Psychology

Human confidence frequently exceeds objective accuracy.

MTMT distinguishes

$$P(\text{correct})$$

from subjective confidence.

The framework therefore encourages epistemic calibration.

16 Psychiatry

The MTMT framework is purely formal.

It is not a diagnostic model and should not be interpreted as describing psychiatric disorders or clinical reasoning.

17 Philosophy

MTMT relates to

- epistemology,
- fallibilism,
- foundationalism,
- coherentism,
- Bayesian rationality.

The principal claim is axiomatic rather than metaphysical.

18 Political Science

Institutions may be viewed as implementing competing meta-frameworks.

MTMT suggests caution regarding constitutional or ideological systems whose supporting meta-frameworks remain unevaluated.

19 International Relations

Competing geopolitical doctrines can be interpreted as competing meta-theories.

Expected robustness depends upon successful validation rather than ideological commitment.

20 Welfare Economics

Suppose

$$W$$

denotes expected welfare.

Then

$$E[W] = \frac{1}{e} W_C + \left(1 - \frac{1}{e}\right) W_I,$$

where

$$W_C$$

and

$$W_I$$

represent welfare outcomes under correct and incorrect governing meta-frameworks.

21 Warfare Economics

Incorrect strategic doctrines may impose large opportunity costs.

Expected strategic utility becomes

$$U = \frac{1}{e} U_C + \left(1 - \frac{1}{e}\right) U_I.$$

22 Military Strategy

Hierarchical command structures naturally possess multiple abstraction layers.

MTMT predicts decreasing confidence in strategic correctness as the chain of abstraction grows, assuming independence.

23 Computer Science

Represent each meta-theory as a graph.

Nodes represent theories.

Edges represent evaluation.

Searching for a correct meta-theory becomes a graph-search problem.

24 Algorithms

Pseudo-code:

```
MTMT_Search(M):

Input:
    Set of meta-theories M

Best <- null

For each T in M

    score <- Evaluate(T)

    If score > threshold

         Best <- T

Return Best
```

Expected correctness prior:

$$\frac{1}{e}.$$

25 Artificial Intelligence

Bayesian AI naturally incorporates MTMT:

$$P(T \mid D) = \frac{P(D \mid T)P(T)}{P(D)},$$

where

$$P(T) = \frac{1}{e}$$

is the prior assigned by the MTMT axiom.

26 Machine Learning

Meta-learning systems recursively optimize learning algorithms.

MTMT predicts exponentially decreasing confidence under repeated independent meta-levels unless additional information updates the prior.

27 Data Science

Suppose competing predictive pipelines correspond to competing meta-frameworks.

Bayesian model averaging may reduce dependence on any single incorrect framework.

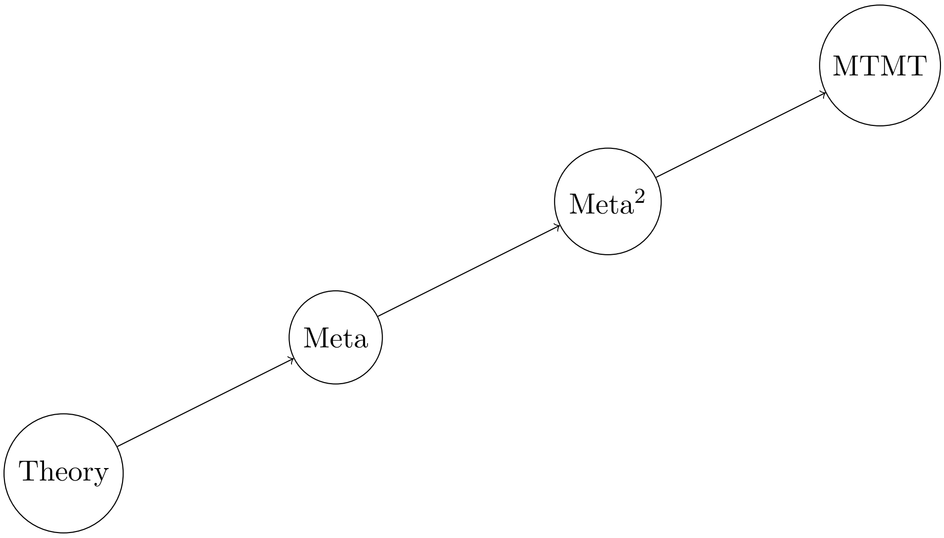

Figure 1: TikZ Illustration.

28 Summary Table

Field	Interpretation	Representative Quantity
Logic	Truth valuation	$P(C) = 1/e$
Probability	Correctness	$1/e$
Statistics	Expected successes	n/e
Economics	Expected value	$\frac{1}{e}R$
Finance	Portfolio weighting	w_i/e
Physics	Exponential analogy	e^{-n}
Biology	Hierarchy	e^{-n}
Computer Science	Graph search	Evaluation
AI	Bayesian prior	$1/e$
Philosophy	Fallibilism	Prior uncertainty

Table 1: Summary Table.

29 TikZ Illustration

30 Conclusion

The Meta-Theory of Meta-Theories is an internally consistent axiomatic framework whose principal assumption is

$$P(\text{correct}) = \frac{1}{e}.$$

From this single assumption emerge exponential confidence decay, Bayesian priors, recursive self-reference, and conceptual links to numerous disciplines. These interdisciplinary connections should be understood as mathematical analogies or research hypotheses rather than empirical laws.

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Glossary

Meta-Theory A theory about theories.

MTMT Meta-Theory of Meta-Theories.

Correct Meta-Theory One satisfying the correctness predicate.

Incorrect Meta-Theory A member of the complement set.

Meta-Level Depth of recursive abstraction.

Confidence Prior probability assigned to correctness.

Bayesian Prior Probability assigned before observing evidence.

Recursive Validation Repeated evaluation across successive meta-levels.

The End